



The Greatest Show On Earth!

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"The Olympics—a lifetime of training for just ten seconds!"

Jesse Owens
At the 1936 Summer Olympics

Once every four years, the world celebrates the only true global sporting event there is—the Summer Olympic Games. With a whopping 4 billion people expected to watch at least part of the events live or on the news, it's by far *"The Greatest show on Earth"*. Whether you watch it for love of sports, or just to cheer your countrymen on, hoping

No, we're not talking about the 1952 Academy Award winning movie!

they win more medals than last time—the fact remains, you *will* be watching.

World records are often smashed at the Games, personal bests almost always bettered, and heroes are often created overnight and showered with gifts and praise from their countrymen. Of course, sometimes, the *Goliaths* of certain sports are felled by a lesser known *David* or two, and *Dream Teams* often have nightmares for years to come—caused by losing to minnows or the underdogs. The Olympic Games inspire athletes from all over the globe to perform out of their skin, and brings elation and sorrow to billions worldwide—and this is the draw of it all!



Images Courtesy:
Omega and Lenovo

However, while you're sitting in the comfort of your home, watching TV and cheering your country on, or while sifting through the temporarily bloated sports pages to see the previous day's results, try and also understand what exactly goes into the organisation of such an event.

Hidden away, behind all the muscular and sinewy athletes that are splashed on every screen or page, are thousands of professionals—hardware and software, networking, broadcast specialists, cameramen and women, etc. All of these people are involved in the event of their lives, some of them for the first time, some seasoned professionals, all of them unsung heroes, of sorts, who work night and day to ensure that everything works just so.

As most of you will testify, technology is seldom fool-proof, with crashes, bugs and more afflicting our gadgets and PCs on almost a daily basis. Yet, thousands of technology professionals at the Olympics have just one task—ensuring that there are no hiccups. With redundant systems for redundant systems, it's all very hectic and nerve-wracking. Take for instance the 100 m dash, which is an event that almost every sports enthusiast watches with excitement. It is, after all, the quest to be the fastest sprinter on Earth for the men and women who qualify and race. However, imagine telling Usain Bolt to re-run his world record breaking 100 m dash (9.72 seconds), because the timing system was broken, or even postponing events because of technical failure? Unthinkable! Unlike the athletes, who can lose this time and still come back and take the glory four years (or four minutes) later, the companies involved in providing expertise and the equipment might not get any second chances.

Beijing 2008

All through August, the world looks towards China for the 2008 Summer Olympic Games. Already shrouded in controversy because of China-Tibet political problems, this time the Games are bigger than ever before—they will be bigger in the future as well, with new technologies, innovations and more eyeballs watching. As we mentioned earlier, about 4 billion people will watch 10,708 athletes from 205 countries compete for medals in 302 events. It's not like there's this one big Olympic stadium where everything happens either. The games are held across 7 cities, and 37 venues, which makes it a networking and management nightmare.

In Good Company

So who is really looking after all the technology that runs the Games? The worldwide IT partner for the Games is Atos Origin (AO), an international IT services company. They've

been handling the Games since Greece 2004, and have partnered with other specialists to provide services to the Olympic Games. AO is a company with annual revenues of 5.4 billion dollars (over Rs 23,000 Crore), and has just one job—to provide a "critical, but invisible, IT system" for the Games. AO oversees the complex designing and building of IT infrastructure in all of the venues at Beijing 2008. They're also in charge of the digital security—physical security for IT equipment—as well as digital security to protect against hackers. After all, hacking the Games would be a crowning moment in any hacker's life. During the Games, AO will command a team of over 4,000 IT professionals, making sure that everything goes according to plan, and right on schedule. They *know* they have no second chances!

AO also runs all the various systems associated with the Olympics, the largest of which is the Games Management System which encompasses every last detail such as who has permission to enter which areas of which venue (players, coaches, judges, etc.), managing the transport arrangements of all athletes, coaching staff, media personnel, etc., the entire qualification system for athletes, planning liaisons between medical personnel and athletes (mandatory drug testing, treating injuries, etc.), the human resources requirements for all Olympic officials and volunteers, and much more. From the broadcasting side, AO will also be behind Information Diffusion Systems, which in English means that AO will manage



Around 600 Lenovo professionals are working day and night to ensure a successful execution of the Olympics